

Star Watching

By Otto Perry

CW: Use of a homophobic slur

I walked into my new office for the first time. The smooth walls reflected and cast pink light across the room, curving inward to create the floor. My superior shows me my desk, covered in buttons and screens, from which I'd create my battle plans. In front of the desk was a view of the city of Zipet, military vehicles mixed in with Tuk-Tuks and bicycles. Past the bustling city are dusty reds and pinks that seem to stretch on forever.

The sun was setting, well, the sun I saw was setting. Just as one sun set in the west, another rose in the east. The only stars I have ever seen.

I stood there, taking the view in before I was interrupted by an over-enthusiastic pat on the back. He agreed that the view was beautiful and joked that I shouldn't get too deep into my thoughts, since I have an important job to do. The view was not on my mind as he left the room, as my lover's face projected over the desert's pinks and reds.

Dewen, my lover, was stationed a galaxy away. Rainy, green-tinted video calls were the only way I was able to see his face for three years. Those shitty screens couldn't capture his beauty, not in a thousand years, not even a million years. That beauty which I only really got to see the week before we were drafted. It felt like the universe hated us specifically, bureaucracy and patriotism putting a galaxy between us.

At least we could talk, I would tell myself, but I yearned for his presence. My imagination is a poor replica of the feeling of his arms wrapped around my chest, or how his smile could brighten

up my whole day. I'm getting caught up in my memories when the door buzzer rings.

"Mail for you." Muffles from the other side of the door, and an envelope falls through the slot.

If there's one thing the Ricite Corporation appreciates, it's 20th-century shit like physical letters.

I wasn't too quick to complain, however, as when I picked up the letter, I noticed it was from my sweet Dewen. My increased heartbeat and nervous fingers reminded me of the romantic novelty of a letter sent a galaxy away. I went to open it before something stole my breath. The red seal that held the company's insignia was peeling back a smidge as if someone tried to press it back on.

Oh my god.

Jeremy, the person assigned to inspect my mail and who would be deemed the necessary sacrifice if somebody sent me a bomb, was the only person who could have opened the letter.

The rank of commander comes with the perk of increased privacy, Jeremy being the only other soul that touched my letters.

As I paced toward his office, thoughts raced through my mind. *What if he has already told them?*

What if my supervisor is already leaning over his desk as Jeremy whispers about our relationship? Thinking about it made my pace increase. My speed-walking past the cubicles did not ease the tension in the place where the war was being waged, but at that moment I was fighting my own battle.

I almost ran into the blast-resistant door to his room, fumbling the lock open before I burst through. Jeremy is there typing on his computer, a look of shock on his face. I'm frozen for a second.

Does he even know? Am I just being paranoid?

“Heyyyyyy, Jeremy, just checking in on ya.” I push the door closed behind me, finding the latch and locking the door without looking. “You’ve been doing a great job lately.” I was already starting to regret this reconnaissance mission, just barging into another person’s room.

“Oh, thanks for checking in, I haven’t blown up yet, as you can obviously see.” He chuckles, the scars and burn marks around his face reminding me had been blown up before, but not bad enough to get moved to another department. Another reason for me to just turn around and leave him alone.

“Welp, that’s good... I’m going to leave now.”

I fire weak finger guns at him as I turn to leave the room. As I was turning the latch, I heard Jeremy mumble something.

“...in love with a footsoldier...”

I twist my head back. “What did you say, Jeremy?” He leans back, his mouth shifting back into a smile. “Did you open the letter you just delivered? You know that lying about that kind of thing might cost you your job, or your life, or both.” I used my position against him, I must admit, and it's not something I’m proud of.

He tenses his shoulders, leaning over his desk as his brows furrow. “Yes, I did, Onyx. Because you’re my friend,” he sighs, “I want to help you keep your job. You can’t have your head in the clouds for some pretty-boy footsoldier. You’re a one-in-a-generation commander, so I’m going to help you pull your head out of your ass. As you know, threatening someone’s job can really motivate them.”

I stopped listening after he mentioned Dewen. All I could see was red.

“You fucker.” I pressed my hands onto his desk, knocking over the Newton’s Cradle on his desk. “Just because you call me a friend does not mean you get to *blackmail* me into breaking up with him. Haven’t I had enough taken away from me? My free time, my energy, and now the love of my life? You are not going to be the one that keeps me from him.”

He stood still, his eyes lined up with mine. “I’m not scared of some queer playing war, wearing his pink shoulderpa- “

Before he’s finished, I’m gripping him with both hands by his collar, “If you tell anyone about me and Dewen, the first person in your barracks to put a grenade under your *fucking* pillow is getting a promotion.” I must admit, my gross abuse of power may have crossed the line, but looking back I think he mostly deserved it.

He slinks back in his chair, sweat building on his brow. “Are we clear?” I practically hissed through clenched teeth. He nods, and I nod back. What felt like only a few moments later I was back in my office, the setting and rising suns deepening the red shades of my office. I slump into my chair, noticing that I still had Dewen’s letter in my suit pocket.

I take it out, carefully peeling back the seal and opening the envelope. I unfold the tiny piece of standard-issue paper that can only hold a few sentences.

For my star Onyx,

I hope getting to be the big man in charge isn’t putting too much pressure on you. I worry about you even though we have no shelter currently. The thought of you rescuing me from this place keeps me going. I look for you out in the stars.

Love, Dewen

Only when I stopped reading did I notice that tears began to stain the piece of paper. I quickly attempted to wipe off my tears from the page, but it just left wet marks. I cried because he had gone through so much, so much more than I ever have.

But then I smiled knowing that someday we'd both be watching the stars together.